

Chapter 46-1: Laughter

Chu Qingqiu didn't speak, only extended her finger to lightly flick Ning Fuyi's claw. Ning Fuyi cried out in pain and fell down, frantically grabbing at Chu Qingqiu's skirt hem in mid-air, using both hands and feet to climb back onto her shoulder.

Hmph, she'd been found out. Ning Fuyi held her claw, thinking to herself, then said: "What's there to fear about ghosts? These are all souls waiting to be reincarnated, not evil spirits. And they're most afraid of screaming sounds - just yell at them a couple times and they'll scatter on their own."

Chu Qingqiu walked around an elderly man and said: "This venerable one does not make unseemly noises."

However, as soon as she finished speaking, there was another impenetrable crowd ahead. Chu Qingqiu suddenly reached toward her shoulder, her fingertip forcefully pinching Ning Fuyi's tail. Ning Fuyi cried out in pain, letting out a long squeak, and the ghosts in front of them automatically parted.

"Chu Qingqiu!" Ning Fuyi's eyes welled up with tears from the pain, shouting at Chu Qingqiu's ear through divine consciousness. Chu Qingqiu's lips loosened imperceptibly, as if she hadn't heard anything, and continued forward on her own.

The two traveled through the crowd of ghosts and finally saw the legendary Bridge of Helplessness. The bridge surface was much wider than the previous wooden walkway, looking no different from ordinary river-crossing bridges in the outside world.

In the center of the bridge stood a large cauldron, from which an unpleasant smell wafted. They could hear bubbling sounds from afar, with dark bubbles splashing out.

Ning Fuyi covered her nose: "I've long heard that people must drink Meng Po Soup¹ before reincarnation, but I never imagined this soup would smell so terrible. Even boiled excrement wouldn't smell this bad."

Chu Qingqiu ignored her crude language and walked onto the Bridge of Helplessness. The ghosts around them were obviously different from those on the Yellow Springs Road earlier - their eyes were no longer vacant, but like living people, either sad and numb, or weeping bitterly. Only a few elderly people who had clearly died of natural causes remained relatively calm.

"Young lady, why did you die at such a young age?" An elderly woman with a hunched back approached them, opening her toothless mouth kindly.

She extended a finger like dried tree bark, poking Ning Fuyi's fluffy belly, sighing: "Even in reincarnation you don't forget to bring an animal with you. You must have been a kind person in life. What a pity."

Ning Fuyi hugged her belly.

"She suffered from a serious illness." Chu Qingqiu lied without blinking.

"I've been standing here for a long time, witnessing many tragedies. Look at that child - born disabled and drowned in the river by his parents." She shook her head, then pointed to another person in despair, "That young man had his family's farmland seized by corrupt officials in town. His parents hanged themselves, and when he went to the capital to seek justice, he was stabbed through the belly by passing bandits."

The child lay on the ground crying, while the man with a sword piercing his waist was drinking a bowl of Meng Po Soup.

However, as soon as the soup entered his stomach, his eyes widened like saucers and he began screaming in agony, desperately trying to pull out the sword at his waist, tearing himself bloody in the process. The sight was too horrible to watch.

This was what the judge had mentioned - there was something wrong with Meng Po Soup. Both Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu frowned.

"May I ask where this Meng Po can be found?" Chu Qingqiu inquired.

"Right behind that cauldron." The old woman pointed to the cauldron that was half a person's height. Chu Qingqiu adjusted her sleeves and walked forward.

The closer they got, the more unbearable the stench from the cauldron became. Ning Fuyi dared to peek inside and saw the cauldron was full of sticky black liquid with several bones of unknown origin rolling around in it, making her nauseous.

Fortunately, ghosts have no sense of taste, Ning Fuyi thought. Though she could see everything in the cauldron clearly, she couldn't find the so-called Meng Po anywhere.

Just when Ning Fuyi thought living people couldn't see Meng Po, a figure finally emerged from behind the cauldron. This person only reached Chu Qingqiu's waist. Though dressed like an old person, the face was that of an eleven or twelve-year-old girl.

This was Meng Po? Ning Fuyi was very surprised.

Chu Qingqiu was also somewhat astonished, but she didn't show it. Instead, she stepped forward and said: "About this Meng Po Soup..."

"Please wait!" The girl spoke irritably. She was so busy her clothes were disheveled, standing on tiptoe as she poured a plate of slimy worms into the cauldron, then stirred it a few times with a huge ladle beside her, ladling out a bowl and pressing it into Chu Qingqiu's hands.

Chu Qingqiu was momentarily speechless, then handed the bowl to a waiting ghost nearby. The ghost took the bowl and gulped it down, threw the bowl away, and began screaming in agony, tearing at his own face as if trying to rip it apart, then suddenly turned around and unexpectedly jumped into the River of Forgetting below the bridge.

Without a splash, his screams stopped abruptly.

Chu Qingqiu had wanted to stop him, but her hand froze in mid-air, her expression showing compassion.

But once a ghost couldn't forget their past life, they absolutely couldn't enter reincarnation - falling into the River of Forgetting was their only fate.

"Why doesn't it work still!" Meng Po was so angry she nearly overturned the cauldron below her. She frantically tore at her own hair, throwing all the pulled strands into the cauldron and stirring again.

"I was invited by Emperor Fengdu² to help. May I ask what ingredients are in this Meng Po Soup?" Chu Qingqiu raised her voice, finally catching Meng Po's attention.

Meng Po still held a handful of hair, looking at Chu Qingqiu with dark circles under her eyes, then suddenly threw down the hair and grabbed onto Chu Qingqiu's robes, beginning to cry.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling! I've been hoping and praying, finally you've come! These past days I don't know what's wrong with the Meng Po Soup. After drinking it, those ghosts not only don't forget their past lives, but each one becomes filled with resentment and refuses to enter reincarnation. If this continues, I'm afraid I won't be able to do my job anymore!"

She cried with snot and tears streaming down, wiping Chu Qingqiu's clothes into a mess. Finally, Chu Qingqiu couldn't stand it anymore and struck the white bone heavily on the ground, stopping her crying.

"Meng Po Soup can be made with flower dew from Red Spider Lilies³ and hair strands from someone who cannot forget their past life." She wiped her nose and said obediently.

"Only flower dew is needed - what's the purpose of adding so many bugs and broken bones?" Ning Fuyi couldn't help but ask.

Unexpectedly, Chu Qingqiu actually repeated her words, asking for her: "Only flower dew is needed - what's the purpose of adding so many bugs and broken bones?"

"Adding more ingredients makes the recipe more complex, so people won't think just anyone can steal my job." Meng Po grinned, then became serious, "Divine Venerable must never reveal this!"

"Your hair is fine, so the problem must be with the Red Spider Lilies." Chu Qingqiu said, turning her skirts, "Take me to see the Red Spider Lilies."

"Yes." Meng Po hurriedly covered the cauldron lid and bowed, "This way please, Divine Venerable."

Footnotes:

¹ **Meng Po Soup (孟婆汤)**: In Chinese mythology, a soup that erases memories of past lives before reincarnation

² **Emperor Fengdu (酆都大帝)**: A deity who rules over the underworld in Chinese mythology

³ **Red Spider Lilies (彼岸花):** Flowers that bloom along the path to the afterlife in Chinese mythology, also known as "flowers of the other shore"